historical legacy as well as its future geopolitical ambitions. The Indian desire to pursue modernity as well as exercise influence in the contemporary world is inextricably linked with a world view shaped by India's rich history and a decision-making process heavily influenced by tradition. India's interaction with other nations is dominated by an Indian world view that pays special attention to India's civilizational heritage as well as its colonial past. The Indian sense of self and of the world, as well as the architecture of Indian institutions, has been profoundly affected by the experiences of the colonial and post-Independence era.

At the core of India's foreign policy lies a desire for autonomy in decision making resulting from the impact of British colonial rule when that autonomy did not exist. While every nation prefers freedom in foreign policy decisions and actions, India emphasizes sovereignty in every policy it makes and every action it takes. This explains the country's unwillingness to sign up as a formal ally of the world's major powers. A strong moral overtone is also visible in India's foreign policy, which can be linked both to its history as well as the extremely moralistic national struggle under India's founding father, Mohandas Karamchand ('Mahatma') Gandhi (1869–1948). There is a strong belief not only that India is destined for great power status but also that India is an example for the world, especially the developing countries.

The vast legacy of India's founding fathers is the direct result of its long independence movement. India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru (1889–1964), played a crucial role in the independence struggle and served as foreign minister in addition to being prime minister for seventeen years. He laid down the principles of Indian foreign and security policy in his writings, speeches and policy decisions. For thirty-five years or so after his death, Nehru's successors preferred to continue with the Nehruvian framework, making only cosmetic changes whenever required.